MEDIEVAL HISTORY × ENGLISH LITERATURE · GRADUATE SEMINAR · 35 MIN (23 TALK + 12 DISCUSSION)

AFTER 1066

The Palimpsest Problem

Old English Residue Under a New Written Order



THE ANOMALY

Conquest models predict the defeated elite's written language vanishes fast. These dates refuse.

1154

THE FLOOD, LATE

The mass influx of French vocabulary is a c. 1250–1400 phenomenon — not an 11th-century one.

1250+

+88 YEARS

Peterborough Chronicle still writing English annals — almost nine decades after Hastings.

c. 1200

VERSE, NOT RELIC

Laȝamon composes ~16,000 lines of alliterative English verse, its working lexicon overwhelmingly Old English–derived.

THE COUNTER-EXPECTATION

The new elite wrote in Latin and French. By the 1070s the chancery had ceased issuing English writs; Domesday (1086) is Latin.

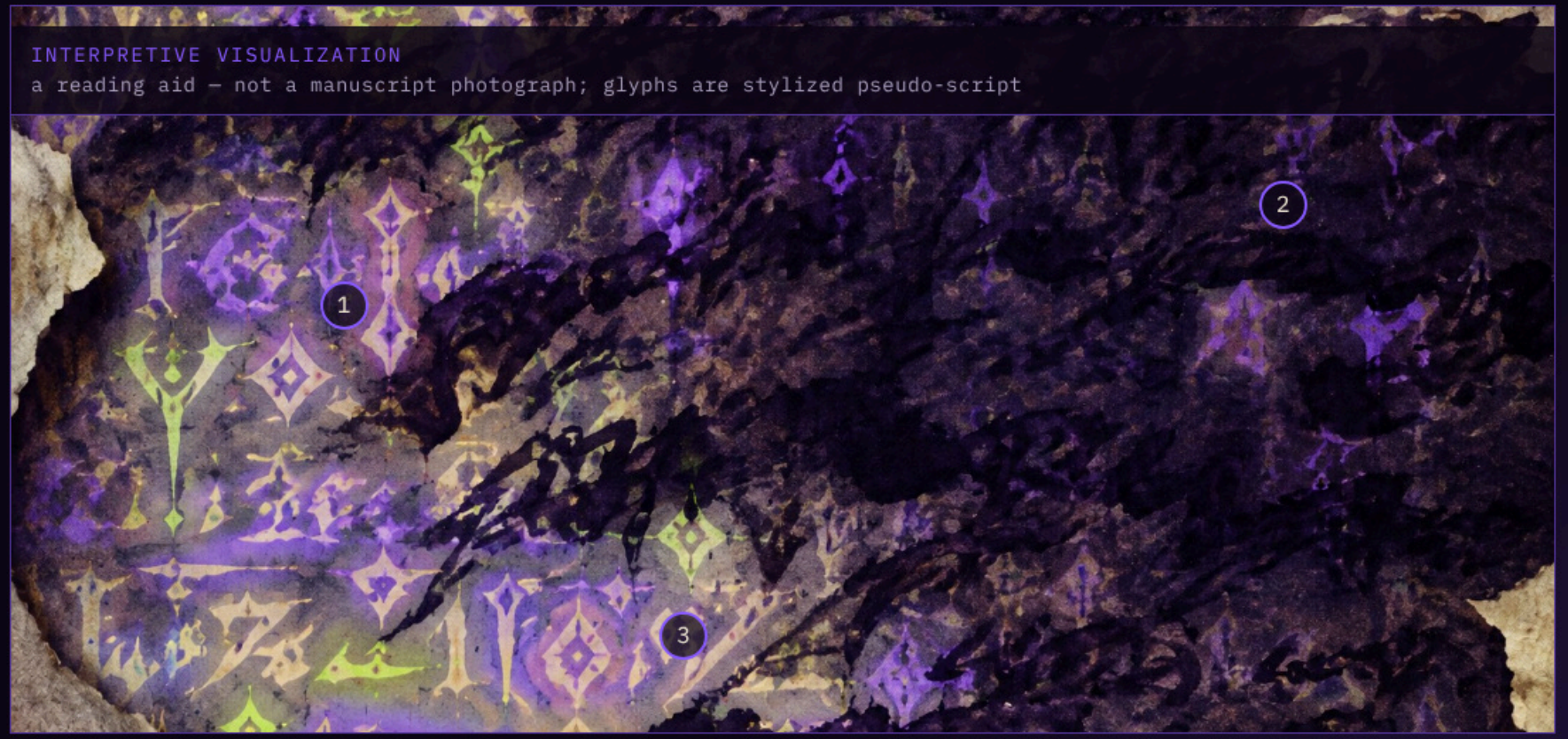
The older layer should have vanished quickly. It did not.

? Why did the French-Latin written order not quickly replace English — and what do the residues prove?

THE ANOMALY — EVIDENCE FIRST

Residue Made Visible

An **older English** keeps surfacing inside the written order that was supposed to replace it.



1 · The older layer

Glowing angular letterforms — the English that was supposed to be overwritten, still legible underneath.

2 · The darker scrawl

A newer written order laid across the surface, dominant but never total.

3 · Where they collide

The residue shows through at the seams — that surfacing is the anomaly this deck tests.

What it stands for is real: **Peterborough Chronicle (MS E)** — Oxford, Bodleian Library, MS Laud Misc. 636 · English annals continued to 1154, long after the French-Latin order arrived.

BEFORE THE ARGUMENT · THE DECK'S WORKING VOCABULARY

Three Terms in Plain Language

Exactly three words carry the whole argument; everything after this page is evidence.



PALIMPSEST

palimpsest — a reused writing surface bearing traces of an erased earlier text

A manuscript page scraped clean and written over, where the older text can still show through — here, a metaphor for English surviving under the new written order.

— Anchor: a reused parchment leaf where the erased older hand still faintly reads beneath the newer lines.

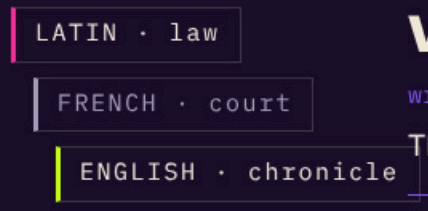


RESIDUE

residue — the persisting remains of a superseded linguistic layer

What remains of the older layer after replacement pressure: surviving words, forms, genres, and habits of writing.

— Anchor: the 1154 annal of the Peterborough Chronicle — English still being written as history is a residue.



WRITTEN ORDER

written order — the institutional hierarchy of literate languages and genres

The ranked system of who writes what, in which language, for which institution — law, church, chronicle, literature.

— Anchor: Domesday Book (1086) sits in Latin at the top; an English annal in Peterborough keeps a lower rank alive.

Two Explanations, One Test

Before the evidence: here is the protocol every later page can be audited against.

A Conquest Rupture

The conquest replaced the elite — and the elite's languages replaced English writing.

B Institutional Reorganization

Institutions were re-staffed and re-ranked, but bilingual negotiation and literary continuity persisted inside them.

01
Define the criteria
C1–C4 — fixed judgment criteria both explanations must face.

→

02
Test five phenomena
Five textual phenomena, each read against **A** and **B**.

→

03
Assemble the ledger
Criteria × phenomena, cell by cell — gaps marked , not hidden.

→

04
Return to the anomaly
What the evidence explains — and where it runs out.

THE TWO LINES NEVER MERGE

Gaps are shown, not hidden. Where the sources are insufficient, the ledger leaves a torn cell — absence stays visible on the page.

EXPLANATION A | THE RUPTURE THESIS — STATED AT FULL STRENGTH

Conquest Rupture

LATIN + FRENCH → take the written order, top down

1066 — THE FAULT LINE

~~ENGLISC~~ ~~WRIT~~ ~~BISCOP~~ ~~CRONICLE~~

1066 destroyed the English-speaking ruling elite **and the institutions that reproduced English writing**. Latin and French did not drift in — they took over the written order from the top down.

ELITE REPLACEMENT

the landholding, literate class was physically dispossessed and replaced — the people who commissioned, wrote, and read English documents were gone.

DIGLOSSIA

a stable split in which high functions — law, church, court — use one language, while low spoken functions use another.

MECHANISMS

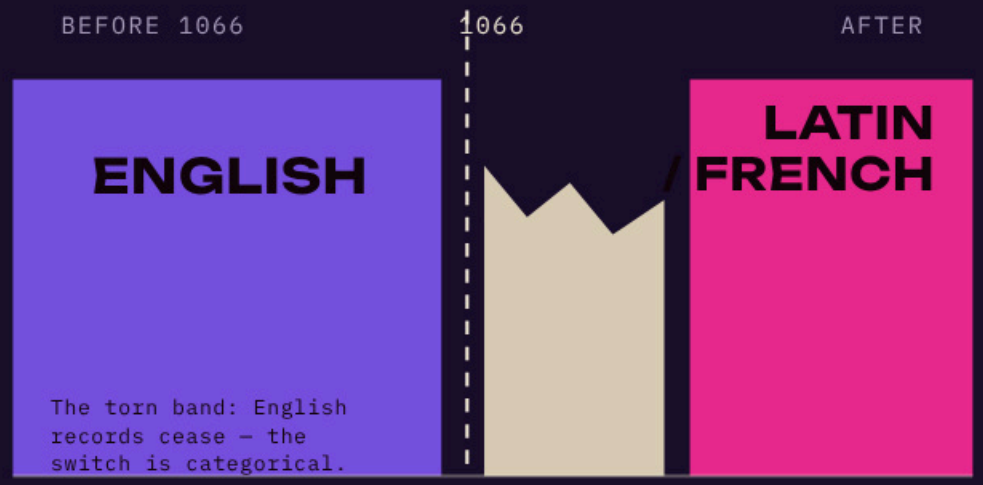
claims to be tested against the evidence — not facts already proven

- → Harried land, transferred land: Domesday (1086) as the written record of a replaced proprietor class.
- → Norman bishops and abbots take over the institutions that trained scribes and kept libraries.
- → Chancery practice shifts royal writing to Latin — the king's documents stop speaking English.
- → Castle and court culture makes French the language of power and prestige.

What Rupture Explains

At the top of the **written order**, replacement is not a hypothesis — it is documented. The open question is how far down it reached.

LANGUAGE OF THE ROYAL RECORD · CATEGORICAL BEFORE / AFTER



Read as states, not percentages. English-language royal documents before 1066; none after the 1070s. No reliable share figures exist, so none are drawn.

Writs & diplomas switch language — DOCUMENTED

Royal writs run in **English** before 1066; by the 1070s the chancery had ceased issuing them — the record turns **Latin**. No single "last English writ" is pinned; the cessation itself is secure (Timofeeva).

Domesday Book, 1086 — DOCUMENTED

The great survey of England is recorded in **Latin** — the state no longer writes English. Yet Old English place- and personal names sit embedded inside the Latin frame: vernacular residue within the new order.

Vernacular book production collapses — ESTIMATE

Almost no new English literary manuscripts between **c. 1066 and c. 1150** outside the Chronicle tradition; survivors are mostly copies of older texts. Qualitative only — no percentage exists (Treharne 2012; Swan & Treharne 2000).

Elite literacy re-manned — DOCUMENTED

Bishops, abbots, and landowners — the people who commissioned writing — are overwhelmingly **continental** by 1087–1100.

Terms reused (glossed pp. 4, 6): **WRITTEN ORDER** · **DIGLOSSIA** · **ELITE REPLACEMENT**

EXPLANATION B THE RIVAL THESIS, IN ITS STRONGEST FORM

Institutional Reorganization

The Conquest **re-ranked** institutions and languages — it did not **erase** English writing. Where institutions housed English — monasteries, regional scriptoria, pastoral care — it persisted, adapted, and negotiated with French and Latin.

HOW IT WOULD HAVE WORKED

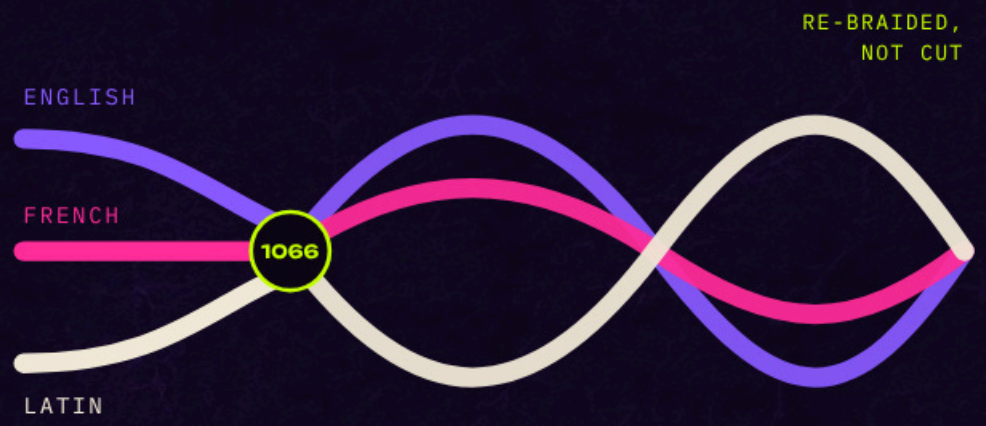
01 Monastic scriptoria keep copying Old English texts after 1066

02 Glossing as active study — older books read, marked, taught

03 Regional literary production resurfaces c. 1200

04 English retained for pastoral and local functions

> Not "nothing changed." B predicts disruption plus persistence in specific institutional homes — that specificity is what makes it testable against A.



Re-ranked, still intertwined — the languages keep crossing in the same houses and the same books.

BILINGUAL NEGOTIATION

Writers and institutions actively worked across languages, choosing per function and audience — not passively surrendering one tongue for another.

INSTITUTIONAL CONTINUITY

The same houses, books, and scribal habits carried pre-Conquest practice forward through the change of regime.

EXPLANATION B EVIDENCE DOSSIER — WHAT REORGANIZATION PREDICTS AND FINDS

What Reorganization Explains

An archipelago, not a continent: written English after 1066 survives in **scattered institutional islands** — abbeys, cathedral priories, regional houses — never as a uniform national practice.

-1154

Peterborough

PETERBOROUGH ABBEY

English annals kept 88 years past the Conquest — last entry 1154.

ASC E-text · Oxford, Bodleian Library, MS Laud Misc. 636 · continuations 1122–1154

Ælfric's homilies still copied and collections updated through the 12th century.

Swan & Treharne (eds.), Rewriting Old English in the Twelfth Century (CUP, 2000)

c. 1200

Worcester

CATHEDRAL PRIORY

The Tremulous Hand systematically glosses the library's OE books — someone is still teaching themselves to read them.

perhaps ~50,000 glosses (est., Franzen 1991) · Ælfric's Grammar & Glossary, OE Bede, and a run of Worcester MSS

c. 1175–1225

West Midlands

REGIONAL HOUSES, OUTSIDE THE COURT

Laȝamon, Brut — first history in English since the Chronicle.

c. 1200, Areley Kings, Worcs. · BL Cotton Caligula A.ix

Ancrene Wisse group & Poema Morale — English re-emerges in writing.

Cambridge, CCCC MS 402, c. 1230 · Trinity Coll. Cam. MS B.14.52

The pattern: English survives **exactly where an institution houses it** — and vanishes where none does.

distribution, not decay
→ tested as criterion C2

Judgment criteria — the exam both explanations must sit

Four questions, fixed before we look at the phenomena. Whatever cannot be located on C1–C4 does not count as evidence either way.

C1 Chronology

When does change hit the written record?

- **A PREDICTS** Change hits immediately after 1066.
- **B PREDICTS** Change arrives delayed and uneven, over decades.

C2 Distribution

Where does English persist or disappear?

- **A PREDICTS** Loss and persistence are uniform across the board.
- **B PREDICTS** Concentrated by institution, region, and genre.

C3 Agency

Who keeps writing and copying English?

- **A PREDICTS** Nobody of standing — the writing class is replaced.
- **B PREDICTS** Identifiable institutions and readers keep it alive.

C4 Directionality

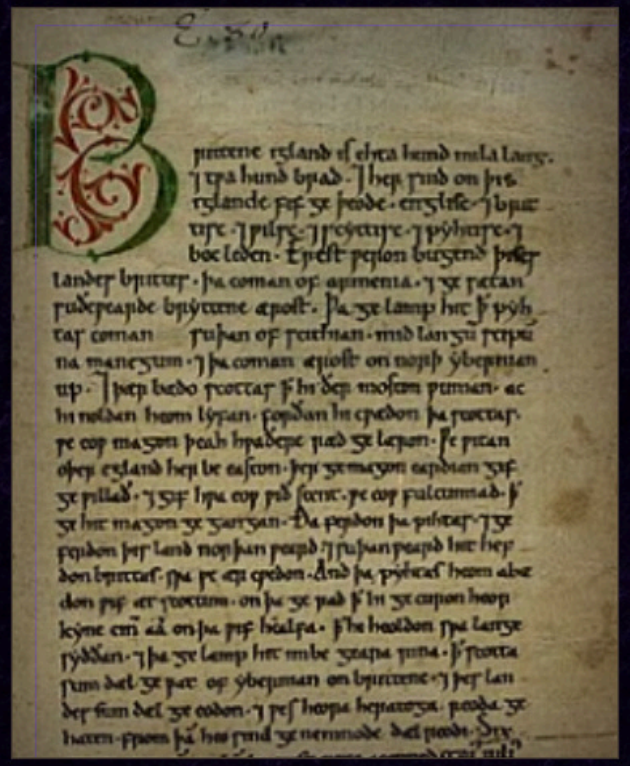
Which way does influence run?

- **A PREDICTS** One way: French and Latin replace English.
- **B PREDICTS** Both ways: translation, glossing, and adaptation.

PRE-COMMITTED: THESE CHIPS RETURN UNCHANGED IN THE EVIDENCE LEDGER — EVERY PHENOMENON GETS SCORED AGAINST THE SAME FOUR QUESTIONS.

PHENOMENON 1 · SPECIMEN P1

The Peterborough Chronicle — English, still being written



Oxford, Bodleian Library, MS Laud Misc. 636, opening page. The hand visible here is the copyist's, writing before 1122 — not the continuators'. Image: Wikimedia Commons (public domain manuscript scan).

ANGLO-SAXON CHRONICLE · MS E

Copied at Peterborough Abbey, after the 1116 fire

Annals in English continued:

First Continuation 1122–1131 · Second/Final Continuation 1132–1154

THE 1137 ANNAL — THE ANARCHY

"…and it was said openly that Christ and his saints slept. These things, and more than we can say, did we suffer during nineteen years because of our sins."

Translation: J. A. Giles (Project Gutenberg #657)

OE: "Þa the suikes undergæton ðat he milde man was and softe and god…"

Its language: late Old English drifting into early Middle English within one manuscript.

National historiography still written in English 68–88 years after the Conquest — inside a re-founded Norman abbey.

CONTINUATION

Later hands keep the annals going in the same book, picking up where the copied text stops.

Testing the Chronicle

Phenomenon 1 vs. both explanations — one criterion at a time: prediction, observation, point.

A — CONQUEST RUPTURE		B — INSTITUTIONAL REORGANIZATION
If rupture were instant, English narrative should die at 1066; the Chronicle is the last gasp that measures it.	C1 CHRONOLOGY	Annals run 88 more years, to 1154 — change is delayed and uneven, not instant. POINT → B
One surviving exception still maps the general collapse of English book production.	C2 DISTRIBUTION	Survival clusters where an institution houses it — one abbey, not a uniform loss. POINT → B
But the abbey was Norman-ruled: even English writing now runs through A's new elite. SPLIT	C3 AGENCY	English scribes keep writing and copying — a living scriptorium at Peterborough. SPLIT
It ends in 1154 and nothing follows: English historiography does stop. PARTIAL A	C4 DIRECTIONALITY	For 88 years the traffic is two-way — copying, continuing, compiling in English.

Verdict — B, with an expiry date

Back to the anomaly: the residue is **institutional**, not accidental.

The Tremulous Hand of Worcester

.i. custodes · wæccan

Heold ða halgan wæccan on þære nihte *.i. nocte*

GLOSS LAYER · C. 1200

.i. legere · rædan

And þa boc rædde fram ænginne oð ende *.i. scripturas*

.i. anima · sawle

For þære sawle hælo he swanc swiðe *.i. laboravit*

.i. verbum · word

MAIN TEXT LAYER · PRE-CONQUEST OE

Þæt ealde word wunode on gemunde *.i. memoria*

SCHEMATIC RECONSTRUCTION — NOT A MANUSCRIPT PHOTOGRAPH

OBJECT CARD

An anonymous scribe of Worcester Cathedral Priory, active **around 1200 over an extended period**, known by his shaky — "tremulous" — hand. He worked through Ælfric and other pre-Conquest Old English texts, adding perhaps **~50,000** interlinear and marginal glosses (estimate — Franzen 1991) across a run of Worcester manuscripts — mostly into Latin, some into Middle English.

FACT 1 — SOMEONE CARED

A living reader in a cathedral library, still actively recovering the old language from books.

FACT 2 — IT HAD BECOME HARD

He needed the glosses: Old English was no longer immediately readable, even to him.

GLOSS

A short translation or explanation written between the lines or in the margin of an older text.

TEST PROTOCOL · RUN 02 · PHENOMENON 2

Testing the Tremulous Hand

c.1200

One Worcester scribe, glossing Old English around 1200 — the same artifact scores for both explanations.

A · CONQUEST RUPTURE	CRITERION	B · INSTITUTIONAL REORGANIZATION
— NO A SCORE A late, isolated effort does not reverse the rupture; the flood of new writing is French and Latin.	C1 · CHRONOLOGY	B SCORES Glossing c. 1200 — a living Old English reading culture 130+ years after the Conquest.
— NO A SCORE One library is a remnant, not a distribution — the exception that measures the loss.	C2 · DISTRIBUTION	B SCORES Concentrated in one cathedral library at Worcester — exactly B's institutional clustering.
PARTIAL A A single individual with a trembling hand — an identifiable agent, but not a system that outlives him.	C3 · AGENCY	B SCORES An identifiable scholarly agent actively curating and studying Old English manuscripts.
A SCORES Glosses run Old English → Latin / Middle English: the old layer now needs translation into the new order.	C4 · DIRECTIONALITY	— NO B SCORE Translation effort confirms the distance — negotiation has already become one-way.

VERDICT · MIXED

A on intelligibility | B on survival

Back to the anomaly: **residue persists as an object of study, not just habit.**

PHENOMENON 3 · LITERARY CONTINUITY AT SCALE

Laȝamon's Brut

c. 1200 · a priest at Areley Kings, Worcestershire · the first history in English since the Anglo-Saxon Chronicle

"An preost wes on leoden,
Laȝamon wes ihoten…"

"There was a priest among the people, who was called Laȝamon" — the poem opens in English, naming its author.

BL Cotton MS Caligula A.ix, opening (catalogue dating: third quarter of 13th c.) · British Library · incipit quoted from the standard EETS edition

LATIN Geoffrey of Monmouth, *Historia Regum Britanniae*

↓

FRENCH Wace, *Roman de Brut* (c. 1155)

↓

ENGLISH

Laȝamon, *Brut* (c. 1200) — c. 16,000 long lines (~16,095 in the standard EETS edition)

The old layer surfaces last — and largest: the most "Old English" poem of the era is a translation of a French book.

<150
French-derived word types

Fewer than ~150 French-derived word types in ~16,000 lines (Monroe 1907) — under 1% of the working vocabulary. Estimate: Monroe counts word types, not tokens; later counts vary by method but agree the proportion is tiny.

ALLITERATIVE VERSE

Verse held together by repeated initial sounds, not end-rhyme — the line-music of Old English poetry.

Testing the Brut

One poem, four criteria. A West Midlands parish priest turns Wace's French into ~16,000 lines of English alliterative verse — what do the two explanations make of it?

READING A — RUPTURE	CRITERION	READING B — NEGOTIATION
B A century and a half after Hastings, English should be a spoken residue — not a language of ambitious new verse at this scale.	C1 · CHRONOLOGY	**B** c. 1200, 130+ years on: a full-scale history in English verse — the first since the Chronicle. Delayed, not immediate, replacement.
B Court and chancery are French and Latin; the prestige map is set. Where this poem lives is outside it.	C2 · DISTRIBUTION	**B** West Midlands regional production, outside court — English writing clustering where institutions house it, not uniform loss.
A NOTE A socially modest author is exactly A's point about WHERE literature now lives: ambitious English has left the elite order.	C3 · AGENCY	**B** A named priest — LaƷamon of Areley Kings — writing for English hearers. Agency is identifiable, chosen, and vernacular.
A HOLDS The prestige pipeline still runs one way: Latin → French → English. Geoffrey's Latin, Wace's French, then LaƷamon.	C4 · DIRECTIONALITY	**B STRONG** Two-way negotiation made literal: French source, English alliterative form, an overwhelmingly OE-derived lexicon.

PROTOCOL VERDICT · P3 — **B STRONG · A KEEPS THE PRESTIGE MAP**

The residue here is not survival-by-accident but a **chosen literary idiom**.

PHENOMENON 4 · WEST MIDLANDS, EARLY 13TH CENTURY

Ancrene Wisse & the “AB Language”

SPECIMEN — THE TEXT, NOT THE PAGE

“I þe Feaderes ant i þe Sunes ant i þe Hali ȝastes nome, her biginneð Ancrene Wisse.”

Incipit of CCCC MS 402 — “In the name of the Father, the Son and the Holy Ghost, here begins Ancrene Wisse.” Note the disciplined spelling: þ, ð and ȝ handled with a consistency no casual copy achieves.

Catalog card. Cambridge, Corpus Christi College MS 402 — the “A” text of Ancrene Wisse; West Midlands, c. 1230 (datings range 1225–1240). Sister manuscript: Oxford, Bodleian Library MS Bodley 34 (the “B” text, Katherine Group).

No openly licensed facsimile image of CCCC MS 402 is available for reproduction; the evidence on this page is the text itself.

Cambridge, Corpus Christi College MS 402 — diplomatic excerpt of the incipit, after the standard edition; no facsimile shown because none is openly available.

A guide for anchoresses, first written for three sisters; its sister manuscript Bodley 34 (“B”) holds the Katherine Group. Tolkien (1929) named their shared dialect the “AB language.”

CCCC MS 402 · Bodleian MS Bodley 34 · West Midlands

THE CLAIM — AN UNBROKEN TRADITION

d’Ardenne; Dobson (1976). AB is a disciplined, standardized written English of unparalleled cross-manuscript consistency — a fixed way of spelling shared across texts and scribes, implying an unbroken scribal tradition reaching back before the Conquest.

THE CONTEST — ONE SCRIPTORIUM’S HOUSE STYLE?

Richard Dance (2003). The consistency may be a single scriptorium’s house style, not a regional standard; the archaic features may be conscious archaism. Date (c. 1200–1235), author (Dobson’s Brian of Lingen vs Millett’s Dominican) and institution are all unresolved.

Millett; Bethurum. The Katherine Group → OE prose continuity link is discredited (Faulkner 2012).

“The mechanism of continuity is precisely the missing link.”

STANDARDIZED WRITTEN LANGUAGE a fixed way of spelling and writing shared across texts and scribes

Testing Ancrene Wisse

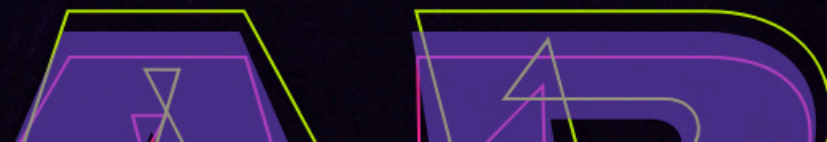
The strongest continuity claim in the deck — and the one whose score depends on a contested scholarly judgment.

A · RUPTURE READS		B · REORGANIZATION READS
A · CONTESTED Composition date genuinely disputed (Shepherd: soon after 1200 · Dobson: 1215–1221); the standardization mechanism cannot be dated.	C1 · CHRONOLOGY	B Standardized written English by the early 13th c. — CCCC MS 402 ("A" text, ca. 1230) shows cross-manuscript consistency.
A One West Midlands pocket: a regional archive, not a national picture.	C2 · DISTRIBUTION	B West Midlands, pastoral/devotional function — English survives where an institution houses it.
A · LIMITS Named recipients: three women. A rule for three anchoresses measures how small the stage of standardized English was.	C3 · AGENCY	B Scriptorium-like discipline (d'Ardenne's AB language), identifiable audience — named anchoresses with a durable rule.
A The very need to argue for a "tradition" shows how little standardized English writing survived to argue from.	C4 · DIRECTIONALITY	B AB prose negotiates Latin source material and French vocabulary selectively — two-way handling, not passive replacement.

CONDITIONAL — B if d'Ardenne's standard-language claim stands · A if Dance's house-style reading wins

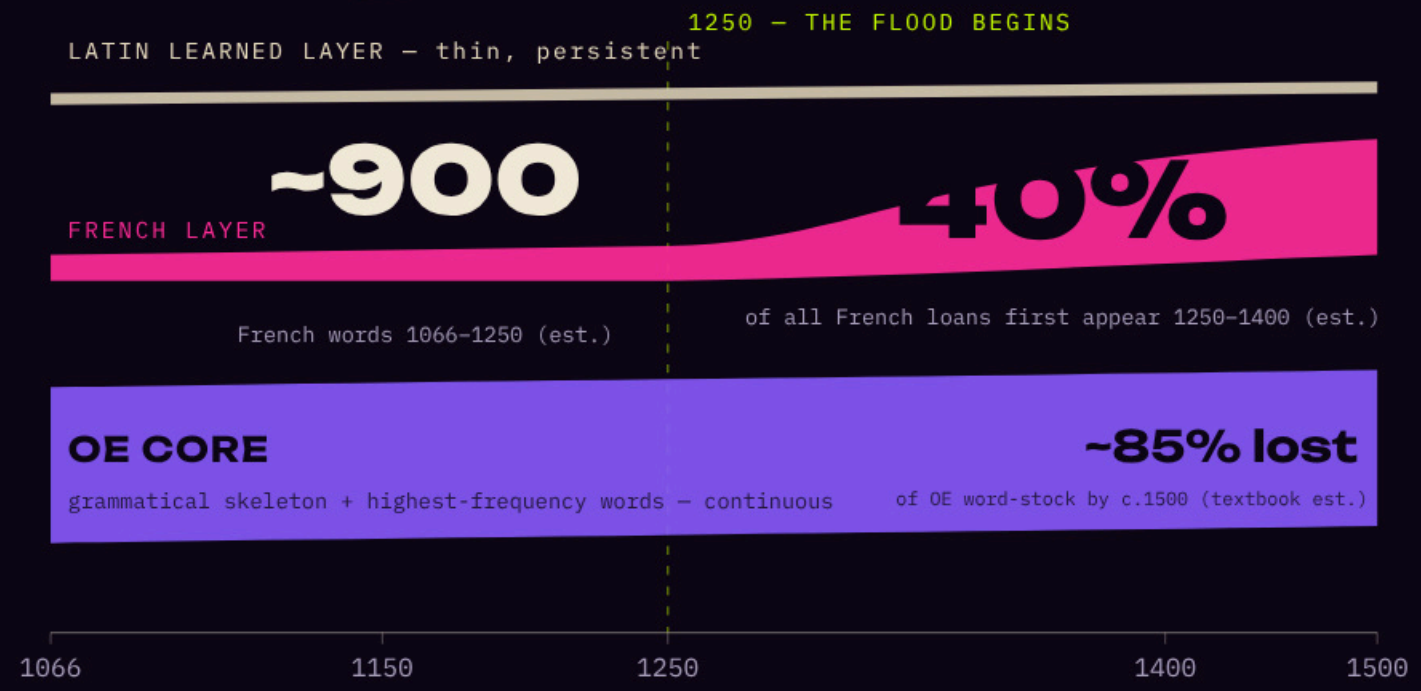
Diagonal seam = the cell holds only under a named scholarly condition; record the condition, not a side.

The residue's meaning depends on a philological judgment, not just a document.



PHENOMENON 5 — THE RESIDUE AT WORD LEVEL

Lexical Strata



Strata widths are schematic, not to scale. Figures are standard estimates in the Baugh & Cable tradition; totals: ~10,000 French words into Middle English, ~75% still in use (est.).

The core holds.

The grammatical skeleton and highest-frequency vocabulary of modern English remain Old English in origin — French dominates the prestige registers: law, government, cuisine, art.

LOANWORD

a word taken from one language into another and made at home there — e.g. baron, feast, servant from French.

TEST 5 / 5 — PHENOMENON 5: LEXICAL STRATA

Testing the Lexicon

When did French words actually arrive — and who chose them?

A — CONQUEST RUPTURE		B — INSTITUTIONAL REORGANIZATION
C1 / A: If conquest replaced the language, loans should flood in immediately after 1066. FAILS	C1 · CHRONOLOGY	Only ~900 French words enter 1066–1250; the flood — 40% of all French loans — first appears 1250–1400, tracking post-1204 social absorption, not Hastings. B, STRONGLY
French enters first in elite-adjacent registers — law, government, cuisine, fashion: the prestige map of a conquered elite. A	C2 · DISTRIBUTION	Yet the OE core holds: the grammatical skeleton and highest-frequency vocabulary stay Old English — negotiated selectivity, not uniform loss. B
C3 / A: Loans imposed top-down by a French-speaking ruling class. FAILS	C3 · AGENCY	The borrowers are English speakers choosing prestige words for their own use — agency sits with the borrowing speech community. B
Directionality runs overwhelmingly one way: ~10,000 French words into English, almost no traffic back. One-way replacement — A's cleanest cell of the five tests. A	C4 · DIRECTIONALITY	C4 / B: Little evidence of negotiation at the lexical level — the ledger must say so. FAILS

VERDICT — B on timing and agency; A on prestige direction.

the dictionary keeps the anomaly's score.

The Evidence Ledger

Five phenomena × four criteria, scored for both explanations — read it by **columns**, not rows.

PHENOMENON	C1 CHRONOLOGY	C2 DISTRIBUTION	C3 AGENCY	C4 DIRECTIONALITY	ANOMALY LINK
P1 Peterborough Chronicle	B — 88-year delay	B — one abbey = institutional	MIXED — English scribes, Norman abbots	MIXED — ends 1154 — English stops	English narrative still written to 1154 — the anomaly's core exhibit.
P2 Tremulous Hand	B — c. 1200, after the rupture	NO EVIDENCE — one reader, one library	MIXED — one reader, not a system	A — OE now needs translation	Residue visible but barely readable — the old layer needs glosses.
P3 Laȝamon's Brut	B — c. 1200	B — West Midlands parish	B — priest-poet, local audience	MIXED — French source → English form; A keeps prestige map	A French poem becomes English verse — negotiation made literal.
P4 Ancrene Wisse	NO EVIDENCE — AB dating unresolvable	CONDITIONAL — if standard-language claim stands	CONDITIONAL — if not — house style	CONDITIONAL — tradition vs. scriptorium	Standardized English c. 1230 — continuity claimed, not proven.
P5 Lexical Strata	B — flood delayed ~200 yrs	MIXED — elite registers A; OE core B	B — speakers chose prestige words	A — one-way borrowing	The French flood arrives c. 1250 — the delay itself is the anomaly.

A — rupture · B — reorganization · MIXED — split reading · CONDITIONAL — depends on contested claim · TORN = no evidence

Torn Gaps

P1 P2 P3 P4 P5

C1

GAP 01

SURVIVAL BIAS

We see only what monasteries chose to keep. The 1116 Peterborough fire and the Dissolution destroyed the comparanda — lost libraries are invisible in our matrix.

C2

GAP 02

THE ORAL RESIDUE

Spoken English between 1066 and 1150 left almost no direct trace. The century our argument hinges on is the century we cannot hear.

GAP 03

REGIONAL SKEW

Every phenomenon on this ledger clusters in Worcester, Peterborough, and the West Midlands. The north and east are dark — C2 distribution is measured on a biased map.

C3

GAP 04

DATING DRIFT

The Tremulous Hand is “around 1200”; Ancrene Wisse floats between 1200 and 1240; Laȝamon between c. 1190 and 1215. Decades-wide windows blunt C1 chronology.

GAP 05

COUNTERFACTUAL VOID

We cannot observe the England where 1066 never happened. Every “continuity” claim is measured against a baseline that does not exist.

C4

A ledger with blank cells is still a ledger.

RETURN TO THE OPENING QUESTION

Return to the Anomaly



THE ANOMALY, RESTATED

The Chronicle still runs in English to 1154; OE-derived verse surfaces c. 1200; the French loan flood waits until c. 1250 — the new written order did not instantly replace the old.

WHAT THE LEDGER EXPLAINS — THREE STRATA

THE DELAY — RUPTURE RULED THE TOP

The French–Latin order took the top of the written order instantly; but English persistence was institutional, so it decayed house by house — not by decree.

THE DISTRIBUTION — NEGOTIATION BENEATH

Residues cluster exactly where scriptoria housed English: Peterborough, Worcester, the West Midlands. Survival follows institutions, not geography of defeat.

THE LEXICON — RESIDUE SURFACING

Mass Frenchification waited two centuries — so "replacement" cannot describe 1066–1150. The old word-stock was still the working layer.

Rupture at the top of the written order; reorganization and negotiation beneath it — the anomaly is both at once.

What the evidence cannot settle

Four questions the tests raised and no surviving source answers — each torn open where the answer would go.

SCALE

How much was lost? We count survivors, not the missing — so how many English books 

Could be answered by: medieval library catalogues or estate inventories listing volumes now gone.

SPEECH

When did the children of the Norman elite start speaking English? 

Documents cannot hear. Could be answered by: reported dialogue, schoolroom notes, or letters written as spoken.

REPRESENTATIVENESS

Does the West Midlands archive describe England —  or describe archiving?

Could be answered by: comparable survivals from eastern or northern houses — if any had survived.

CAUSE

Where continuity is documented, was it caused by negotiation — or by neglect, institutions too poor to be reformed 

Could be answered by: administrative records of who paid for copying, and why.

SYNTHESIS · AFTER THE LEDGER

Two Explanations, Partial Scores

NO VERDICT DECLARED

A

CONTINUITY

C1·C2·C3·C4

RUPTURE

B

THE OVERLAP

The anomaly is overdetermined — both explanations are true of different layers of the same written order.

A · RUPTURE

2 / 20 outright

A owns the top of the written order — writs, Domesday, the directionality of prestige.



2 outright · 4 mixed cells shared · 3 conditional · 2 torn — ledger p.21

B · REORGANIZATION

8 / 20 outright

B owns chronology, distribution, agency — the delay, institutional clustering, active readers and writers.



8 outright · 4 mixed cells shared · 3 conditional · 2 torn — ledger p.21

WHAT WOULD CHANGE THE SCORE

- New manuscript finds
- Refined dating of the AB language
- Better quantification of document survival

This is where the evidence stops; the argument is now yours.

Discussion Rules

Every question goes to exactly one bucket.

12 minutes · roughly **4 per bucket**
protocol, not a conclusion

BUCKET 1

SOURCE AUTHENTICITY

Can we trust this manuscript, edition, translation, dating?

questions arrive live **~4 min**

BUCKET 2

LITERARY INTERPRETATION

What do the residues mean — form, audience, intention?

questions arrive live **~4 min**

BUCKET 3

FURTHER READING

What would settle it — and where do we look?

questions arrive live **~4 min**

RULES OF THE FLOOR

- ☐ Name the evidence before the claim.
- ☐ One criterion per objection — "which C does this move?"
- ☐ Torn gaps are valid moves: you may park a question in a gap.
- ☐ No appeals to what "must have happened."

DISCUSSION LAUNCH — 12 MINUTES

The Three Buckets

Every question goes in a tray. Seeded starters below — add your own.

SOURCE AUTHENTICITY

? The Peterborough scribes wrote under Norman abbots — does patronage change what the annals can prove?

? The Tremulous Hand is one reader — how many readers make a tradition?

LITERARY INTERPRETATION

? Is the Brut's Old English idiom a survival or a revival — and how would we tell?

? What does it mean that England's most English poem is a translation from French?

FURTHER READING

→ Elaine Treharne, *Living Through Conquest: The Politics of Early English, 1020–1220* (Oxford UP, 2012).

→ Christine Franzen, *The Tremulous Hand of Worcester* (Clarendon Press, 1991).

→ Mary Swan & Elaine M. Treharne (eds.), *Rewriting Old English in the Twelfth Century* (Cambridge UP, 2000).

→ Albert C. Baugh & Thomas Cable, *A History of the English Language* (Routledge).

→ Mark Faulkner, "Rewriting English Literary History 1042–1215," *Literature Compass* 9 (2012).

The residue is on the table. Sort your questions.